



BOUNDLESS, PRICELESS, AND THREATENED

THE WORLD NETWORK OF BIOSPHERE RESERVES (1983)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Environmental law

BEFORE

1821 Naturalist Charles Waterton creates the first nature reserve in Walton Hall, Yorkshire, UK.

1872 US president Ulysses S. Grant makes Yellowstone the world's first national park.

1916 The first state-run "strict nature reserve" is set up in Russia for scientific study.

1916 US president Woodrow Wilson establishes the National Park Service.

AFTER

1992 The Convention on Biological Diversity is adopted.

2016 Canada's giant Tsá Túé Biosphere Reserve is created by a Dene First Nation people.

2016 The world's largest marine reserve is created in the Ross Sea off Antarctica.

The biosphere is the surface "skin" around Earth that supports mankind and all other forms of life. In 1971, UNESCO launched its Man and the Biosphere Programme (MAB) with the aim of encouraging economic development that would be environmentally sustainable while protecting the natural world. In 1972, in Stockholm, the Conference on the Human Environment was the first forum aimed at addressing international environmental issues. Among its recommendations was the setting up of "biological reserves" to protect threatened flora and fauna.

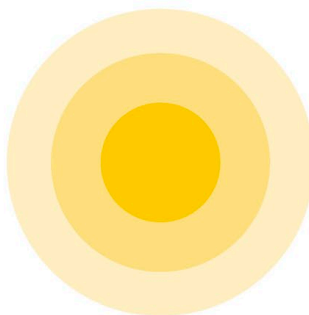
At the time, concerns were growing about deforestation, air and water pollution, overfishing,

and population declines in many wild animals. The first 57 Biosphere Reserves (BRs) were selected in 1976. In the years that followed, more were designated, and a plan for a World Network of Biosphere Reserves (WNBR) arose from a UNESCO-sponsored conference in Minsk, Belarus, in 1983.

Mutual benefits

According to the UN's 1992 legally binding international Convention on Biological Diversity (ratified by 193 nations as of 2020), "Ecosystems, species, and genetic resources should be used for the benefit of humans, but in a way that does not lead to the decline of biodiversity." Recognizing that

A Biosphere Reserve's zones



- **The core zone** is a strictly protected area where human activity is limited and life forms and ecosystems (communities of interacting species and the environment on which they depend) are conserved.
- **The buffer zone** is used for monitoring, scientific research, training, and education.
- **The transition zone** is where people live and work and where sustainable cultural and economic activity is allowed.